

WHAT IF YOU *DON'T* HAVE INSURANCE?

(This is a modification of an article I posted to Thought Catalog in 2013.)

When I was in the ninth grade, my dad lost his job, and we lost our health insurance. That's when I started using my high school science teacher, Mr. K, as my primary health care provider.

"Mr. K," I'd say, poking my head into his lab, "let's say I had some pain on the left side of my stomach right here. Would that be my kidney, and also what can I do to make it not hurt?"

"Mr. K, hey!" I'd say, my face pressed against the glass window of the teacher's lounge. "If I have this weird bump on my knee and it hurts, should I just ice it or do I have knee cancer? Also, is knee cancer a thing you can have?"

"Gaby," he'd always reply, exasperated. "I am not a doctor. I can't legally diagnose you."

"Right. But like, my ear is kind of ringing, and what if I have scurvy?"

My time being "treated" by Mr. K showed me that you can be resourceful about health care. Here are some ways to do that—and let me know if you want Mr. K's home number. I have no boundaries.

USE Groupon-TYPE SITES TO SEE A DENTIST OR DERMATOLOGIST OR OTHER SPECIALIST

The same websites that offer discounted massages and half-off gym memberships can also get you cheap dentist appointments (and sometimes other medical care). The only problem with these Groupon-type deals is they can be a way for the doctors' offices to get you in and then milk you for more procedures. I checked over and over again that everything they were doing was covered by the coupon. It cost \$60 for a teeth cleaning. (Usually without insurance, a teeth cleaning is anywhere from \$80 to \$200.) The dentist tried to talk me into multiple other procedures, for \$500 or more. Don't let them get you. Get in, get what's on the coupon, and get out.